2.3 Wartime Prison Camps

In war, there are always unintended consequences. During the Civil War, neither side was prepared to provide shelter and food for thousands of war prisoners. For those unfortunate enough to be captured, imprisonment could be worse than death.

MAIN IDEA Thousands of soldiers on both sides of the conflict died from exposure and disease in Civil War prison camps.



CRITICAL VIEWING On July 6, 1864, the first 400 Confederate prisoners arrived at the barracks of Camp Rathbun, soon to become the prison camp at Elmira, New York. The barracks could accommodate 6,000 soldiers, but housed more than 10,000 prisoners between 1864 and 1865. Based on details you notice in this photo of the Elmira prison camp, how would you describe the camp and the conditions for prisoners?

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PRISONERS IN THE NORTH

In the early years of the Civil War, the Union and the Confederacy exchanged prisoners of war rather than maintaining prisons. Cooperation soon broke down between the two sides, however, and captured soldiers were confined in military prison camps on both sides.

Camp Douglas in Illinois received its first prisoners—approximately 5,500—in February 1862. It would house more than 26,000 Confederate prisoners by the end of the war. Many prisoners were already sick or wounded when they arrived at the camp, and many died while there due to lack of medical care. Poor sanitation, harsh weather conditions, and reduced **rations**, or supplied food, weakened the remaining prisoners. These circumstances left the prisoners susceptible to infectious diseases such as pneumonia and smallpox. Still others died from **scurvy**, a disease linked to malnutrition and a diet lacking in fruits and vegetables. The total death toll has been estimated to be as many as 6,129 men, the greatest mortality statistic of any Union prison.

Alton was another Illinois prison camp. Originally the first state penitentiary built in Illinois, it closed in 1860, but then reopened in 1862 to relieve overcrowding in other Union prisons. Soon Alton became overcrowded as well. When smallpox swept through the camp in 1862 and 1863, authorities built a hospital on an island in the Mississippi River to **quarantine** infected prisoners, or keep them away from those who had not yet contracted the disease.

Elmira prison camp in New York operated from July 6, 1864, until July 11, 1865. Even though it was set up for 6,000 men, more than 10,000 arrived. Because of overflow, some prisoners camped along the nearby Chemung River.

CAMPS IN THE SOUTH

The largest and most notorious Confederate military prison camp was **Andersonville**, located in Georgia. A creek that flowed through the 16-acre compound provided water for the prisoners, but it quickly became polluted with human waste, making it a perfect breeding ground for contagious diseases. The camp, built for 10,000 men, soon held 33,000 prisoners.

Situated on a 54-acre island in the James River near Richmond, Virginia, Belle Isle prison camp operated from 1862 to 1865, housing more than 30,000 men. In 1864, Surgeon De Witt Peters described the horrific conditions experienced by Union prisoners at Belle Isle.

PRIMARY SOURCE

> Laboring under such diseases as chronic diarrhea, . . . scurvy, frost bites, general debility, caused by starvation, neglect, and exposure. Many of [the prisoners] had partially lost their reason. They were filthy in the extreme, covered in vermin. . . . nearly all were extremely emaciated [very thin]; so much so that they had to be cared for even like infants.
>
> —from testimony to the U.S. Sanitary Commission, by De Witt Peters, 1864

Approximately 13,000 of the 45,000 Union prisoners eventually held at Andersonville died because of exposure, starvation, and brutality. Northerners were enraged when they heard about the conditions at the military prison. After the war, Andersonville's commander, Captain **Henry Wirz**, was executed for war crimes.

Overall, between 12 and 16 percent of southern and northern prisoners died in military prison camps during the war. The deplorable prison camp conditions, both in the North and in the South, led to prison reform efforts after the war to build safer, more sanitary, and more humane prisons in the United States.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the general conditions of most Civil War prison camps? Provide evidence to support your answer.
2. **ANALYZE LANGUAGE USE** What words did De Witt Peters use to describe Belle Isle prison camp, and why might he have chosen those words?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What effect did wartime deaths at prison camps have on the U.S. prison system after the war?

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